All of the delta's inhabitants were Iraqi tribesmen. East of the delta's borders was an expanse of desert that basically extended to Pakistan and Afghanistan. There were three urban centers in the "dry" area of the province. The first was the city of Abadan on the shores of the Persian Gulf, where the oil industry was concentrated at the time, run by a very large community of energy experts of different nationalities. The second was Khorramshahr, about a half hour's drive north of Abadan. This city served as the commercial port and Iran's southwestern point of departure to the Persian Gulf and from there to the Indian Ocean. The third city was Ahwaz, about two and a half hours north of Abadan. This city was the administrative center of the province and was referred to by the Arabic speakers as "Arabistan" and by the Iranians as "Khuzestan." The province's demographics were mixed, consisting of both Iraqi Arabs and Iranians.

Throughout history, the province was inhabited only by Arabs. The Iranian government, aiming to solidify its sovereignty in the province, initiated a campaign using financial and other incentives to encourage Iranians from other provinces in the enormous country to relocate to Khuzestan. The province of Khuzestan and the Iran- Iraq border were sources of contention between the two countries that lasted for many years and were often catalysts for crises and military action.

In order to properly complete my description, I must add that the weather in this desert province was extreme. Summer temperatures approached 122 degrees Fahrenheit with 100 percent humidity. You could crack an egg on the roof of a car and it would turn into an omelet within two minutes. The desert coolers in the house would become blocked from the humidity and stop working. Market vendors would stand in barrels full of water behind their stands. The daily routine would begin at five in the morning. At 10:30 the city would "shut down" and anyone who didn't need to wouldn't go out into the street. The city would wake up again only at four in the afternoon. This is where we lived for two and a half years; it's where we raised our eldest daughter and where we learned about Persia and the Persians.

And what did we learn? It would be impossible to recount everything. Therefore, I will try to summarize the most important insights we gained, those that helped me consolidate my worldview and opinions and assisted me throughout my career—especially in my role as director of the Mossad